

was the strong growth of white spirits that stood out, with vodka and gin sales advancing by double digits and agave-based spirits (all spirits made of the agave plant; tequila is specific to Mexico like champagne is to France) surging by 80%, the report says.

“India’s tequila market is experiencing rapid growth due to a combination of factors. This includes a rising demand for premium spirits, the expanding cocktail culture in urban areas, and a desire to experiment with new spirits among new-age consumers who are entering the market,” says Adtnu Tiwari, Category Lead-Premium White Spirits at Bacardi India. The company currently offers two variants of tequila in the Indian market—Patrón Silver and Patrón Reposado. It has increased its presence from two cities in 2023 to 15 cities across India today. “We’re also introducing an exciting new offering in the ultra-premium segment in India in Q3 of [calendar year] 2024,” says Tiwari.

Competitor Diageo launched its ultra-premium tequila brand Don Julio 1942 in India in April this year. Karina Sanchez, Don Julio Global Brand Ambassador, says that India is an extremely important market for the brand. According to her, the popularity of tequila is due to the spirit’s versatility. “You can have tequila, not just in a classic Margarita or Paloma, but you can also have it in an Espresso Martini (typically made with vodka) or an Old Fashioned (typically a whisky cocktail),” says Sanchez, adding, “The other thing is that Mexican culture is trending across the globe, including India.”

Since tequila or rather the larger parent category—agave—is plant-based, it is considered healthier with a lower calorie count, adding to the spirit’s popularity.



as more ‘sessionable’ compared to sipping spirits like single malt and cognac. Bartenders are also constantly on the lookout for new and flavourful spirits to add to their repertoire, and agave has become extremely popular in this regard,” says Achanta.

Agrees chef-entrepreneur Tarun Sibal, who set up an agave-focussed bar at Barfly in Goa last year with 15 signature cocktails and an extensive agave list. “Our guests were asking for tequila/agave-based

The tequila market in India is expected to grow at a compound annual rate of 12.69% from 2024 to 2032, says India Tequila Market Report 2023

Vikram Achanta, Founder and CEO of alco-bev training company Tulleeho, recently set up the country’s first agave club, which brings together like-minded people to share their passion for agave. “Consumers today are increasingly curious and are looking beyond just purchasing a spirit—they’re seeking out experiences, direct interactions, and conversations that bridge the gap between them and the brand,” he says.

Tequila also has a youthful, fun vibe, as it is considered a celebratory drink in Mexico. “As a sipping drink or with a mixer, agave spirits are definitely seen

drinks and that was our biggest benchmark. When my consumer is asking for a Mezcal Negroni, we better be able to serve it,” he says adding that at his New Delhi-based bar, KhiKhi, one out of four cocktails sold are tequila-based.

CELEBRITIES AND TEQUILA

Globally, there is a trend of celebrities entering the tequila market. From George Clooney’s Casa Amigos to Michael Jordan’s Cincoro Tequila to Kendall Jenner’s